

AI Product Development: Design Course Description

Catalog Year: 2027, Required Hours: 720, Credits: 24

Foundation Core (Required Hours: 360, Credits: 12)	Credits	Hours
Introduction to AI Product Development	1.00	30.00
Product Thinking and Planning	2.00	60.00
Software Systems and Architecture	2.00	60.00
Software Development with AI	3.00	90.00
AI Agents and Automation	4.00	120.00

Design Track (Required Hours: 360, Credits: 12)	Credits	Hours
UX Foundations and Human-Centered Design	2.00	60.00
Visual Design and Prototyping	3.00	90.00
Design Systems	2.00	60.00
User Research and Usability Testing	3.00	90.00
Product Management, Roadmapping, and Agile Practice	2.00	60.00

Foundation Core Courses (Required Hours: 360, Credits: 12)

Foundation Core (Required Hours: 360, Credits: 12)	Credits	Hours
Introduction to AI Product Development	1.00	30.00

The Introduction to AI Product Development course orients students to the world of AI-powered software development before any technical work begins. Students get a plain-language introduction to how AI systems work: what they are doing when they generate text, code, or decisions, and where they commonly fall short. The course also maps out what a modern technology company looks like: the roles on a product team and how those roles collaborate. The course closes with every student publishing a simple website built almost entirely with AI assistance.

Course Objectives:

- Explain in plain language how AI systems generate outputs and where they commonly fail.
- Identify the key roles on a software product team and describe how they collaborate.
- Describe how a technology organization is structured and where individual roles fit within it.
- Use AI tools to plan, build, and publish a simple website without prior technical experience.

Product Thinking and Planning	2.00	60.00
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The Product Thinking and Planning course introduces the product development lifecycle from idea to launch: identifying a real user problem worth solving, gathering and prioritizing requirements, and translating a rough idea into a plan a team can act on. Students learn to write user stories and acceptance criteria and use a basic prioritization framework to decide what to build first and what to leave out.

Course Objectives:

- Describe the stages of a typical product development lifecycle from idea to launch.
- Identify a real user problem and articulate why it is worth solving.
- Write clear user stories and acceptance criteria.
- Gather, prioritize, and scope product requirements using a basic prioritization framework.
- Produce a one-page product brief that translates an idea into an actionable plan.

Software Systems and Architecture**2.00****60.00**

The Software Systems and Architecture course builds the conceptual foundation every student needs before writing code. Students explore how computers process and store information, learn core data structures, develop a working understanding of how the internet functions, and study the design patterns and data modeling principles that shape how real software is architected. Rather than analyzing an arbitrary app, the course project has students take a product idea of their own and produce the architectural plan for it: the data model, the API surface, the client-server structure, and how information would need to move through the system end to end. The goal is to build the habit of designing before building. Responsible data practices are introduced here too, with attention to what the proposed product would collect, why, and what students are accountable for as its future developers.

Course Objectives:

- Demonstrate understanding of computer architecture, memory, storage, and operating system concepts.
- Apply common data structures to organize and manage information in a program.
- Explain how the internet works, including HTTP, DNS, and client-server communication, and how APIs move data between services.
- Apply software design patterns and data modeling principles to plan how a system should be structured.
- Produce an architectural plan for a product idea, including its data model, API surface, and system boundaries.
- Identify responsible data collection practices and describe the privacy implications of design decisions.

Software Development with AI**3.00****90.00**

The Software Development with AI course is where students go from a plan to a working system. Students set up a professional development environment, write code in a general-purpose programming language, and use AI coding assistants and prompt engineering as core tools. Throughout the course, students critically evaluate the code AI produces, write tests to verify that AI-generated code actually does what it claims before it ships, and practice the judgment to know when to trust AI output and when to rewrite it. Ethical use is embedded in all projects through the principle that the developer is responsible for everything they ship, regardless of how it was written.

Course Objectives:

- Set up and navigate a professional software development environment including version control.
- Write and organize code using a general-purpose programming language.
- Use AI coding assistants and prompt engineering to accelerate development without sacrificing understanding.
- Critically evaluate AI-generated code for correctness, security, and appropriateness before shipping.
- Write tests to verify that AI-generated code behaves as intended before it ships.
- Build and deploy a scoped application that solves a defined, familiar problem using AI assistance.
- Design, build, and present a self-directed final project that turns a product idea into a working system.
- Articulate the developer's ethical responsibility for AI-assisted output.

AI Agents and Automation

4.00

120.00

The AI Agents and Automation course teaches students to design, build, and deploy agentic AI systems and automated workflows. Starting with no-code and low-code platforms, students progressively work with direct API integrations and agent frameworks to build systems that take real actions on behalf of users. The course covers how agents perceive inputs, reason through tasks, and produce outputs; how to design and sequence multi-step agentic workflows; and how to evaluate and debug agent behavior in production. Ethical considerations are central throughout: students examine the risks of autonomous systems, determine when human oversight is required, build appropriate guardrails, and reason through what accountability looks like when an agent makes a mistake that affects a real person.

Course Objectives:

- Build automated workflows using no-code and low-code platforms.
- Connect applications and services using APIs, webhooks, and event triggers.
- Explain how AI agents perceive inputs, reason through tasks, and produce outputs.
- Design and implement a multi-step agentic workflow using an agent framework.
- Evaluate and debug agent behavior using logging, testing, and prompt refinement.
- Identify failure modes of autonomous systems and implement appropriate guardrails.
- Apply human-in-the-loop design patterns in contexts where oversight is required.
- Articulate an accountability framework for agentic systems that affect real users.

Design Track Courses (Required Hours: 360, Credits: 12)

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UX Foundations and Human-Centered Design

2.00

60.00

The UX Foundations and Human-Centered Design course introduces the fundamentals of human-centered design: how to translate a user problem into personas and journey maps, how information architecture shapes usability, and how to communicate a design idea through low-fidelity wireframes before any visual polish is applied. Starting from a defined product problem, students develop personas, a user journey map, and a wire-framed user flow.

Course Objectives:

- Explain the principles of human-centered design and why they shape product outcomes.
- Develop personas and user journey maps from a defined product problem.
- Apply information architecture principles to organize content and navigation.
- Produce low-fidelity wireframes that communicate a user flow clearly.
- Define a product problem and translate it into a UX foundation for further design work.

Visual Design and Prototyping

3.00

90.00

The Visual Design and Prototyping course takes students from wireframe to a working, high-fidelity prototype. Students learn core visual design principles (typography, color, layout, and hierarchy) and pair them with AI-powered design tools to generate, iterate, and refine interface concepts faster than manual design alone allows. The course also covers accessibility standards (WCAG basics) and responsive design across device sizes. From there, students build interactive, clickable prototypes that simulate real product behavior, turning static screens into something that feels and behaves like a working product. Students produce a polished, high-fidelity, interactive prototype for a wire-framed user flow, using AI tools as a drafting and iteration partner.

Course Objectives:

- Apply typography, color, layout, and visual hierarchy principles to interface design.
- Use AI-assisted design tools to generate and iterate on interface concepts.
- Design responsive layouts that adapt across common device sizes.
- Apply WCAG accessibility basics to color contrast, text sizing, and interactive elements.
- Critically evaluate AI-generated design output and revise it to meet usability and brand standards.
- Build interactive, clickable prototypes that simulate real product behavior.
- Produce a high-fidelity, interactive prototype for a wire-framed user flow.

Design Systems**2.00****60.00**

The Design Systems course teaches students to design at scale rather than screen by screen. Students learn to identify what belongs in a shared design system versus what stays a one-off decision, then build that system out: reusable components, design tokens, and documented patterns that keep a product consistent as it grows. The course also covers how to prepare a design system for handoff to engineering, with clear specs, usage guidelines, and annotations a development team can act on without guessing. Students build a small component library from a high-fidelity interface, complete with documentation ready for handoff.

Course Objectives:

- Explain the purpose and structure of a design system, including components, tokens, and patterns.
- Identify which interface elements belong in a shared system versus a one-off design.
- Build a reusable component library from an existing product interface.
- Document component usage guidelines and design specifications.
- Prepare a design system for handoff to engineering teams.

User Research and Usability Testing**3.00****90.00**

The User Research and Usability Testing course teaches students to validate design decisions with real users instead of assumptions. Students learn common research methods (interviews, surveys, and moderated usability testing) and how to choose the right method for a given question. The course covers how to write a research plan, recruit representative participants, and run a testing session without leading the user. Students run testing across multiple rounds against an interactive prototype and a set of interface components, revising their materials between rounds based on what they learn. Students also learn how AI tools can accelerate analysis of qualitative data (interview transcripts, survey responses) while examining where that automation introduces bias or loses nuance. The course closes with a findings report that translates research into prioritized, actionable design recommendations.

Course Objectives:

- Select an appropriate research method for a given design question.
- Write a research plan and recruit representative participants.
- Conduct a moderated usability test without leading or biasing the participant.
- Test an interactive prototype and design system components with real users across multiple rounds.
- Synthesize qualitative research data into clear, prioritized findings.
- Use AI tools to accelerate analysis of research data while identifying where automation introduces bias.
- Produce a usability findings report with actionable recommendations for the prototype and design system.

Product Management, Roadmapping, and Agile Practice**2.00****60.00**

The Product Management, Roadmapping, and Agile Practice course zooms out from individual screens to the practice of managing a product over time. Students learn how product managers build and prioritize roadmaps, balance stakeholder input against user needs, and translate design and research work into a backlog a development team can execute. The course covers agile ceremonies (stand ups, sprint planning, retrospectives) and how designers operate inside them, plus how to pitch a product vision to stakeholders. Students close the course by assembling their own design and research work (personas, prototype, design system, and usability findings) into a product roadmap and a final stakeholder presentation.

Course Objectives:

- Explain how product roadmaps are built, prioritized, and communicated to stakeholders.
- Translate design and research work into a backlog of actionable items for a development team.
- Participate in agile ceremonies and describe the designer's role within them.
- Balance competing stakeholder priorities against user needs in product decisions.
- Assemble personas, design work, and usability findings into a cohesive product roadmap and stakeholder presentation.